

Guide Booklet

For everyone trying the beta. No need to read this front to back — when you are stuck, look it up below.

CHAPTER 1

Getting started

How to use this booklet

There is no need to read this front to back. Type a word into the search box above — "saving", "disappeared", "revolve" — and only the matching entries remain. The chapter tabs on the right jump too.

The same content can be searched inside the app — 〈Settings〉 → 〈Search the Guide〉 . Whenever you are stuck, look it up first.

This is a beta

Stage Sketch is still being built. Some things will misbehave, and some things will be confusing. "This didn't work" and "I got lost here" are exactly the reports we want most — please send them without hesitation (→ Chapter 10).

CHAPTER 2

What Stage Sketch is

What it draws

A tool that draws one stage scene two ways at once — 〈Front〉 as the house sees it, and 〈Plan〉 from directly above. Place performers, aim the lights, draw route arrows, line up scenes, and the flow of a show gathers into one sketchbook.

It is a 2D study book for composition, colour and distance. It is not a drawing that decides stage machinery, rigging, safety distances or construction dimensions (the same disclaimer appears in the app itself).

Ways in — opening and signing in

Open it and sign in

Open the URL from your invitation in a browser and it will ask for a name and password. Enter exactly the ones you were given. Once you are in, that device will not ask again for a while.

After some time it may ask again — just sign in with the same name and password.

On a computer (the full toolkit)

Drawing works best on a computer. Stage machinery, the 3D camera and music exist **only in the PC version**. Please use a reasonably recent browser.

On an iPad (Add to Home Screen)

Open the URL in Safari, then use the Share button → 〈Add to Home Screen〉. From then on it opens like any other app, and it starts even with no signal (only that first addition needs a connection).

To suit drawing with a finger, the menus are grouped a little differently from the PC. If you cannot find stage machinery, the 3D camera or music, nothing is broken (→ Chapter 8).

On a phone (the viewer)

The phone is the viewer. Step back and forth through the scenes, import a show file you have received, and export a copy of your own. For drawing, use a computer or an iPad.

The first run

The built-in tour teaches first

The first time you open the app, a short nine-step tour begins. It is not reading — you actually move a performer, add a person, pick a pose, draw a route, make the next scene, watch the transition, add a light, pin a note, and export an image. By the time your hands stop, a scene exists.

Closing it partway is fine. 〈Settings〉 → 〈First-time tour〉 brings it back from the start at any time.

Three things to try after the tour

- Re-choose the form and size under 〈Venue size〉 — from a proscenium frame to a touring tent to a full circle, including three real venues (Theatre Tram, TOHU, Cirque d'Hiver).
- Use 〈Cast & set〉 → 〈Build a set〉 to shape a platform or a prop of your own.
- In the Scenes panel, set 〈Transition duration〉 and 〈Blackout〉, then watch the show flow end to end.

A map of the screen

The top bar

⟨Undo⟩ and ⟨Redo⟩ take operations back — when something goes wrong, start here.
⟨Present⟩ shows the front view alone, full screen (arrow keys step the scenes, Esc returns).
⟨Export image⟩ turns the picture into a file.

The gear, ⟨Settings⟩, holds the feature switches and the language toggle, plus the help group (Quick Guide, First-time tour, Search the Guide, Guide Booklet, Send feedback), along with ⟨Differences by device⟩, ⟨About This App⟩ and ⟨Reset this device⟩.

Changing tools

What happens on the picture depends on the tool in hand: ⟨Move objects⟩, ⟨Move lights⟩, ⟨Draw an arrow⟩, ⟨Paint backdrop⟩, ⟨Erase backdrop⟩, and ⟨3D Camera⟩ PC only. The same grab does different things with a different tool.

Front, Plan, Both

The same stage is drawn as ⟨Front⟩ (from the house) and ⟨Plan⟩ (from directly above).
⟨Both⟩ shows the two together, and ⟨Swap⟩ trades their places. The front view can also be seen from different seats — ⟨Front row⟩, ⟨Balcony⟩ and so on.

Press ⟨Performer names⟩, ⟨Set names⟩ or ⟨Light name⟩ to show name tags in the picture.

The scene strip

The scene strip is on the right. ⟨◀ Previous⟩ and ⟨Next ▶⟩ step through the scenes (the ↑ ↓ keys work too). Stepping forward plays the movement along the routes, and ⟨↺ Transition⟩ replays it. Each scene can carry its own note.

Feature guide

Show

The container for a work. 〈New show〉 starts from blank; 〈Create from a structure template〉 starts from a shape. Move between shows with 〈All shows〉, and carry them as files with 〈Export〉 and 〈Import〉 (→ Chapter 9).

〈Print sheet〉 opens a page with every scene laid out one by one — your browser's print dialog turns it into a PDF.

Venue size

Choose the form and the size, then 〈Build this room〉 assembles the stage. Besides proscenium, thrust, big top, outdoor stage and black box, there are two circus forms — 〈Chapiteau〉 (a touring tent) and 〈Circus in a theatre〉. Three real venues are included: Theatre Tram (Tokyo), TOHU (Montreal — contemporary circus, fully in the round), and Cirque d'Hiver (Paris, 1852 — the classical one-ring house). A custom option takes your own dimensions. A venue on its own can also be exported and passed along as a file.

Choosing a venue shows a note below the panel describing what kind of room it is.

Cast & set (performers, set pieces, props)

The roster of everyone and everything in this work. Type a name, press 〈Add〉, and it steps straight onto the stage. Size and colour are decided here; where it stands in each scene is decided by moving it on the picture.

Performers can take any of 30 poses from 〈Pose〉 — somersault, Cyr wheel, unicycle and more.

Build a set / Saved sets

〈Build a set〉 inside 〈Cast & set〉 combines boxes and boards into set pieces of your own. A finished stage layout can be kept under 〈Saved sets〉 with 〈Save〉, named, and called back later.

Stage machinery PC only

Revolves, moving decks, curtains of every kind, water, lifts — the moving parts of a stage. The ready-made presets include a full front-curtain set and a double revolve (dimensions are estimates; adjust them after placing). The machinery can also play its movement along with the scene transitions.

This panel exists only in the PC version.

Lights

Type a name and press **⟨Add⟩**. Four kinds: overhead (straight down from the batten), side light (across from the wings), front light (from above the house onto faces), floor light (from the floor onto the body). Switch the tool to **⟨Move lights⟩** and the fixture and the pool of light can be grabbed separately. **⟨Build from preset⟩** offers the standard rigs.

Backdrop

Set the base colour, then paint over it with the brush. **⟨Screen text⟩** projects words onto the backdrop — type them and press **⟨Project⟩**. A photo of your own can also be laid in as the backdrop.

Music PC only

Load music files from this device and assign them to scenes. **This panel exists only in the PC version.**

Audio files stay on this device only — they are not included in exported show files or shared sessions. On another device, pick the original files again.

Scenes

Where the scenes are gathered into a show. Besides **⟨New scene⟩**, **⟨Make a scene at the end of the routes⟩** turns the destinations of the routes you have drawn into the next scene. The reverse also works: **⟨Draw routes from the next scene⟩**.

⟨Section+⟩ groups scenes into acts, and **⟨Grid⟩** lays every scene out at a glance. Each transition takes its own **⟨Transition duration⟩** and **⟨Blackout⟩**. **⟨Delete⟩** removes a whole scene; next to it, **⟨Clear the stage⟩** empties only what is placed in the current scene and its backdrop paint (other scenes are untouched).

Selection

Fine adjustments for whatever you grab on the picture. Name, size, colour, facing — the fields change to match what is selected.

Saving

Changes save automatically inside this device's browser — there is no save button to press. But **a file copy is never taken automatically**. Use 〈Export〉 at every good stopping point (→ Chapter 9).

〈Live sharing (for meetings)〉 also lives in this panel (→ Chapter 7).

3D Camera PC only

The 〈3D Camera〉 tool looks into the stage you have built, in three dimensions. Check the composition from any seat in the house or any spot on stage. **PC version only.**

The house has people in it. Switch between 〈Full house〉 and 〈Empty house〉 on the right — the audience on the night, or the empty room before they come in. Turn around from upstage and you can see how the house wraps around you; in a venue in the round it goes all the way.

Shared sessions

When you are invited

Open the invite link, sign in with your usual name and password, enter a display name and join. When you join, your own work is automatically set aside into All shows — nothing of yours gets overwritten.

What you can do in a session

As a guest you can point with the laser pointer and draw arrows. Performers and props cannot be moved, and the scene always follows the host — so that everyone in the meeting is looking at the same moment.

When someone acts, their name appears at the top of the screen ("Now editing: …"). Use it as the cue to take turns.

Hosting one yourself

To talk something over while showing your own show, open `<Live sharing (for meetings)>` in the `<Saving>` panel, enter a display name, press `<Start a session>`, copy the invite link and send it. Once everyone has left, the session fades away after about ten minutes.

If the connection drops

If the line drops, the session reconnects on its own once the host is back up. If it has not returned after a short wait, enter again through the invite link.

Differences by device

What works where

	PC	iPad	Phone
Draw and make scenes	○	○	—
Stage machinery	○	—	—
3D camera	○	—	—
Music	○	—	—
Shared sessions	○	○	○
Export and copies	○	○	○
Offline start	—	○	—

A "—" means **not carried on that device — not broken**. It follows each device's role: the PC is the drawing desk, the iPad the drawing board you carry, the phone the viewer. The full table also lives in the app under <Settings> → <Differences by device> .

Where your work lives

How saving works

Everything you draw lives **only inside the browser of the device you are using**. Nothing goes to a cloud, and it will not appear on another device. To carry work over, use `<Export>` in the `<Show>` panel to make a file, then `<Import>` on the other side. That round trip is the whole story.

Keeping copies (our one request)

In-browser storage can vanish — a browser data cleanup or a storage squeeze is enough. **At every good stopping point, press `<Export>` and keep the file.** This is the single most important request of the beta. As long as the file exists, `<Import>` brings everything back.

What makes work disappear

- The browser's "clear history and site data" erases your drawings with it.
- In a private (incognito) window, everything disappears when the window closes. Use a normal window.
- Audio files are not part of the export. On another device, pick the music files again.

When you're stuck, and sending feedback

Frequent questions

Q. I can't find music, stage machinery or the 3D camera

They are PC-only features (→ Chapter 8).

Q. My work doesn't appear on another device

Saving is per device. Carry work over with export and import (→ Chapter 9).

Q. I moved or deleted something by mistake

⟨Undo⟩ , top left. If a whole show is gone, ⟨Import⟩ your exported copy.

Q. The screen looks wrong or out of date

Reload the page. On the iPad home-screen version, close it and open it again.

Q. It asked for my name and password again

That happens from time to time by design. Sign in again with the same details.

Q. The iPad won't open offline

Only the first ⟨Add to Home Screen⟩ needs a connection. After that it starts offline.

Sending feedback and bug reports

⟨Settings⟩ → ⟨Send feedback⟩ opens the form. One line is plenty — for the good things and the bad.

For a bug, four details change how fast it can be fixed:

- The device you were on (PC, iPad, phone)
- Which screen
- What you did
- What happened (just as you saw it — screenshots welcome)

If it is urgent — "my work disappeared" — don't wait for the form; message me directly.

